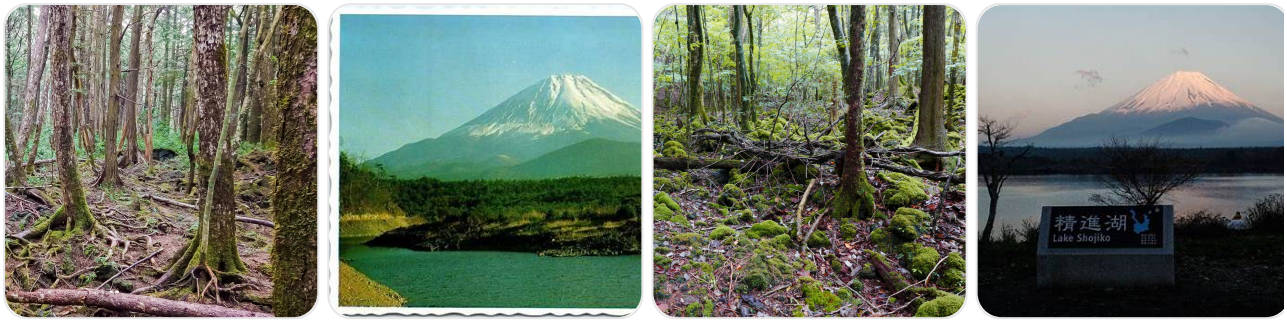




Fifteenth century only — **1400–1499** — gives a hard, almost anti-climactic but important answer:

Aokigahara is not yet a suicide forest, not yet a “sea of trees” discourse-object in the modern sense, and not yet the protagonist of its own cultural history. In the fifteenth century, the real historical object is Fuji’s north-western foot as a threshold zone between mountain worship, lake-edge settlement, pilgrimage infrastructure, Shugendō, roads, and marginal forest/lava terrain.

The deepest fifteenth-century insight is this:

Before Aokigahara became a forest of disappearance, Fuji became a mountain of ascent.

That is the axis of the century. The fifteenth-century world is not “enter the forest and vanish”; it is “approach Fuji, lodge, purify, ascend, worship, return”.

1. The first rule: do not smuggle the twentieth century backwards

For 1400–1499, I found no reliable evidence that Aokigahara was a recognised suicide site, a literary death-place, or a public “no-return” destination. The later association with suicide belongs to the twentieth-century chain; even the strongest pre-Matsumoto candidate is the 1928 Shōjiko double-suicide layer, not the fifteenth century. So the honest fifteenth-century answer has to be built from **absence plus adjacent structures**.

That absence is not empty. It tells us what Aokigahara was *not* yet. It was not yet a media object. It was not yet a police/clinical object. It was not yet a dark-tourist object. It was not yet Matsumoto’s vanishing-stage. It was a difficult lava forest sitting beside lake settlements and Fuji religious routes.

2. The physical forest existed, but the cultural centre was not the forest

By 1400, the Aokigahara lava forest had existed for more than five centuries after the 864 Jōgan eruption. The modern JTB resource describes the Aokigahara lava flow as having

devastated Fuji's north-west foot and then allowed a new forest to regenerate on thin soil over cooled lava, creating the distinctive moss, roots, conifers and lava-cave ecology. That physical world is already there in the fifteenth century. But the available fifteenth-century cultural evidence does not treat "Aokigahara" as the central named symbolic object. It treats Fuji, its routes, its shrines, its caves, its lakes, and its pilgrim infrastructure as the meaningful objects.  全国観光資源台...

So: **the forest is physically mature but culturally backgrounded.**

That is crucial. The later imagination makes the trees central. The fifteenth century still makes **Fuji** central.

3. The fifteenth-century transformation: Fuji becomes mass-climbable

The strongest fifteenth-century fact is the spread and institutionalisation of Fuji ascent.

Fujinomiya's official history says that from around the twelfth century, Fuji's eruptions quietened and the mountain changed from a distant deity-mountain into a Shugendō training mountain. It then says that in the **fifteenth to sixteenth centuries**, faith-ascent by groups guided by religious practitioners became widespread, and that the climbing routes were opened in roughly the fourteenth to late fifteenth centuries; lodging facilities for pilgrims also began to appear.  Fujinomiya City

That means the fifteenth-century "deep structure" is not death. It is **access**.

Fuji is being converted from a mountain to be worshipped from below into a mountain ordinary people can approach, climb, and ritually experience.

This is the absolute opposite of Aokigahara's later meaning. Later: one enters nature to leave society. Fifteenth century: one enters sacred nature through organised religious infrastructure.

4. The north-side route: 吉田口 is being prepared for mass pilgrimage

The north-side evidence matters because it is geographically closer to the Aokigahara/Fuji Five Lakes world than the southern Murayama route.

Fujiyoshida's official World Heritage page says the **Yoshida ascent route / 吉田口登山道** starts at Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine and goes to the summit; by the **late fourteenth century**, lodging for pilgrims had begun to appear, and the infrastructure for large numbers of climbers developed. Yamanashi's official World Heritage material says

essentially the same: by the late fourteenth century, shukubō were appearing for pilgrims and facilities were being prepared for many people to climb.  Fujiyoshida City +1

That is slightly earlier than the fifteenth century, but it is the immediate inherited condition of the fifteenth century. In 1400–1499, the north foot is no longer just wild approach-ground. It is becoming **pilgrimage logistics**: shrine, route, lodging, ascent, guides, religious traffic.

So the Aokigahara-adjacent world is being pulled into a Fuji ascent economy, not into a forest-death economy.

5. The southern religious centre: Murayama is the big fifteenth-century Fuji institution

For the fifteenth century, Murayama is more documentarily visible than Aokigahara.

Murayama Sengen Shrine / Murayama Kōbōji was the centre of Fuji Shugendō.

Fujinomiya's official page says Murayama had become a centre of Fuji mountain practice, that Dōkō of Shōgo-in visited in **1486**, and that by this period Murayama seems to have become part of the Honzan-ha Shugendō network; by the early Sengoku period, under Imagawa patronage, religious practitioners and pilgrims gathered and lodging houses or temple quarters stood around it.  Fujinomiya City

This matters because fifteenth-century Fuji is institutionally being organised through **Shugendō houses, guides, lodging, temple-shrine complexes and ascent practice**.

Aokigahara is not the named centre. Murayama is.

That tells us how fifteenth-century religious space worked: people did not simply wander into “nature” for private dissolution. They passed through religious nodes.

6. 1486: Dōkō's passage is the century's best elite witness

The key fifteenth-century witness is **Dōkō / 道興**, Shōgo-in monzeki, born 1430 and died 1501. He travelled from Kyoto in 1486 and wrote the travel work **廻国雜記 / Kaikoku Zakki**. Kotobank describes the text as a late-Muromachi travel record from 1486–1487, mixing brief entries with waka, haikai, Chinese poems and linked verse. It also notes that the text is valuable for understanding religious-mountain movement, even though it is literary as much as documentary.  コトバンク +1

The Fujinomiya source says Dōkō visited Murayama in **Bunmei 18 / 1486**. That visit matters because Dōkō was not a random tourist. He was a high-status Shōgo-in figure moving through a network of sacred mountains, Shugendō institutions and poetic geography.  Fujinomiya City

This is the closest thing to a fifteenth-century “deep perspective”: not a suicide account, not a local ghost tale, but an elite Shugendō/literary traveller encountering Fuji’s religious landscape.

The emotional grammar is not horror. It is **pilgrimage, poetry, route, shrine, mountain, autumn, snow, sacred ascent**.

7. 1486 also shows what is *not* happening

This is important. Dōkō’s world gives us sacred Fuji, Murayama, travel poetry and mountain religious movement. It does **not** give us Aokigahara as suicide forest.

That absence is not proof that nobody ever died or got lost in the lava forest. Of course people could die in mountain/forest terrain. But it means there is no fifteenth-century evidence of a socially recognised Aokigahara death-destination comparable to the modern one.

The cultural focus is elsewhere: Murayama, ascent, shrine-temple complexes, Shugendō, route-making.

8. The fifteenth-century image-system: Fuji Mandala, not Aokigahara deathscape

The key visual object is the **Fuji Mandala** / 富士曼荼羅図 tradition.

The national cultural-property database describes the important 絹本著色富士曼荼羅図 as a Muromachi-period painting showing the scene of Fuji ascent worship: pilgrims visiting Fuji Hongū Sengen Taisha, Murayama Sengen Shrine, halls and shrines at the foot, and then ascending Fuji; Buddhas and bodhisattvas appear at the summit, showing the syncretic Shinto-Buddhist belief structure. The database says it is important as a precursor to later pilgrimage mandalas and that the depicted shrine layout gives a terminus before Tokugawa Ieyasu’s 1604 reconstruction.  Kunishitei Data...

Fujinomiya’s page identifies the same mandala as a late-Muromachi work, associated with the Kanō school, and says it depicts pilgrims visiting foot-shrines and then climbing Fuji, with Buddhist figures at the summit.  Fujinomiya City

This is essential. The fifteenth-century/late-Muromachi visual imagination of Fuji is not a forest that swallows people. It is a **vertical sacred itinerary**:

foot shrine → Murayama → halls → ascent → summit → buddhas.

Modern Aokigahara is horizontal disappearance. Fifteenth-century Fuji mandala is vertical revelation.

9. The forest is therefore a periphery to an ascent diagram

If you put the mandala logic together with the route/lodging evidence, Aokigahara's position in the fifteenth century becomes clearer.

It is not absent because it does not physically exist. It is absent because it is not the focal sacred diagram. The sacred diagram is **Fuji as mountain-body**. The relevant movement is upwards.

Aokigahara sits on the north-west foot, beside the lake system, but the central cultural image is not “enter the trees”. It is “ascend the mountain”.

That means the later death-image did not grow from a fifteenth-century forest cult. It grew much later by detaching the forest from the ascent system and making the horizontal entry into trees itself the meaningful act.

10. The roads and lake settlements: documentary visibility is weaker for the fifteenth century

For the north-west foot specifically — Shōji, Motosu, Saiko/Nishi-no-umi, Kuisiki — the hard open-web documentary record becomes much clearer in the sixteenth century, not the fifteenth.

For example, Motosu appears concretely in **1545** in *Kōhokusai-ki*, as a stop in Takeda–Imagawa–Hōjō diplomacy; Shōji appears in **1554** in a mortuary record and **1577** in a Takeda document; Saiko/Nishi-no-umi appears in a **1597** document about recalling runaway peasants. These are not fifteenth-century facts, so I am not using them as fifteenth-century proof. I'm using them as a warning: the source horizon for the Aokigahara-adjacent villages becomes much more visible only just after the fifteenth century.

㊤ コトバンク +2

That means we have to be disciplined. For 1400–1499, we can say the region is almost certainly part of the older road/lake/mountain world, but the explicit local documentary hooks available in open sources mostly begin later.

So the most precise statement is:

The fifteenth century gives strong Fuji-pilgrimage evidence, but thinner Aokigahara-village evidence.

11. The likely road-world: Naka-michi exists as the later spine, but fifteenth-century proof is thin

The **Naka-michi Ōkan** / 中道往還 later runs from Kōfu south through the Kuisiki region, past Shōji and to Motosu, linking Kai and Suruga. Kotobank describes its route clearly:

through Ubaguchi, Furuseki, over Anan-zaka, with Lake Shōji to the side, reaching Motosu. コトバンク

For the fifteenth century specifically, the open sources I found do not give a neat dated 1400s Aokigahara road document. But structurally, by the sixteenth century this corridor is already strategic. That makes it likely the road-world was already forming earlier, but the disciplined claim is weaker:

By the fifteenth century, Fuji ascent routes and lodging are documentarily visible; the Aokigahara-adjacent Kai–Suruga road system is best documented from the following century.

That matters because the fifteenth-century answer should not pretend certainty where the source record thins.

12. The wrong model: “wilderness outside society”

The fifteenth-century material does not support “Aokigahara as empty cursed wilderness”.

Even where Aokigahara itself is not richly named, the surrounding Fuji world is visibly structured by:

- pilgrimage routes;
- lodging for pilgrims;
- Shugendō institutions;
- Murayama temple-shrine complexes;
- elite religious travel;
- visual mandalas of ascent;
- shrines and foot-of-mountain ritual nodes.

The forest may have been difficult, dark, and locally dangerous. But the wider region is not outside society. It is being ritually and logistically organised.

13. The psychological register of the fifteenth century

This is the key contrast.

The modern Aokigahara register is:

- I want to disappear.
- I want not to be found.
- I want to exit the human ledger.
- The forest absorbs me.

The fifteenth-century Fuji register is:

I want to approach the sacred mountain.

I pass through religious nodes.

I purify and ascend.

The mountain transforms me.

These are not the same. But they share one deep structure: **leaving ordinary space for a charged natural threshold.**

That is the continuity. The discontinuity is the outcome.

Fifteenth century: return transformed.

Twentieth century: vanish unreturned.

14. The “death” layer in the fifteenth century is not Aokigahara suicide

If we are strict, the fifteenth-century death layer is mostly indirect.

Fuji is a sacred mountain under Buddhist-Shinto syncretic reading; its summit can be figured with buddhas and bodhisattvas in mandala imagery. Ascetic practice and Shugendō always involve bodily danger, suffering and symbolic death/rebirth. But I found no fifteenth-century source making Aokigahara itself into a chosen death-place.

So the phrase should be:

fifteenth-century death-adjacency = sacred mountain ordeal, not forest self-erasure.

That is the cleanest possible distinction.

15. What the fifteenth century contributes to the later Aokigahara myth

It contributes five ingredients, but not the myth itself.

First, **Fuji is no longer only distant deity; it is approached and climbed.** This creates the habit of entering dangerous Fuji nature for transformation.  Fujinomiya City

Second, **routes and lodgings create managed access.** Sacred nature becomes reachable through human systems.  Fujiyoshida City

Third, **Murayama establishes a powerful Shugendō frame.** Fuji is interpreted through guide-priests, temple-shrine complexes, halls, practices and ascent.

 Fujinomiya City

Fourth, **visual mandala culture turns Fuji into an itinerary-image.** The mountain is mapped spiritually: foot, shrine, ascent, summit, Buddhist world.

Fifth, **Aokigahara remains background terrain**. Its later charge partly comes from being the non-itinerary zone: not the shrine path, not the guided ascent, not the return route — later it becomes meaningful precisely as the place off the script.

That last point is the most important.

The fifteenth century gives Fuji a script. The later suicide forest is powerful because it is the anti-script.

16. Century-specific source hierarchy

For 1400–1499, the sources rank like this.

1. Dōkō's *Kaikoku Zakki* / 1486 Murayama visit.

Best single fifteenth-century witness to Fuji's sacred-travel world. It gives elite Shugendō/literary movement through Fuji-Murayama, not Aokigahara death.

 Fujinomiya City +1

2. Murayama Sengen Shrine / Kōbōji history.

Best institutional source for fifteenth-century Fuji Shugendō: Murayama as centre, Dōkō's 1486 visit, likely Honzan-ha absorption, later Sengoku patronage.

 Fujinomiya City

3. Yoshida route / shukubō evidence.

Best north-side route evidence: by late fourteenth century lodgings appear and infrastructure for mass ascent develops into the fifteenth-century world.

 Fujiyoshida City +1

4. Fuji Mandala tradition.

Best visual source-family for late-Muromachi Fuji: ascent, syncretic shrine-temple practice, summit Buddhism, pilgrimage itinerary.

 Fujinomiya City +1

5. Later place-name entries for Shōji/Motosu/Saiko/Kuisiki.

Useful only as control evidence showing that the Aokigahara-adjacent villages become explicit in sixteenth-century documents; not enough to fill the fifteenth century with invented detail.

 コトバンク +2

Final fifteenth-century thesis

In the fifteenth century, Aokigahara is not yet the death forest. It is the dark, lava-grown north-western margin of a Fuji world whose main movement is not disappearance but ascent.

The named and visible fifteenth-century systems are Fuji Shugendō, Murayama, Dōkō's 1486 sacred travel, the development of pilgrim lodgings, the Yoshida ascent route, and the

Fuji Mandala imagination of foot-shrine-to-summit ascent. The Aokigahara-adjacent lake/road villages are not yet richly exposed in the accessible fifteenth-century record; they become much clearer in sixteenth-century documents. So the honest answer is that the forest itself is still culturally peripheral, while Fuji's religious infrastructure is becoming central.

The deepest formulation is:

The fifteenth century does not create Aokigahara as a place to vanish. It creates Fuji as a place to approach.

That is the historical root. Later Aokigahara will invert that system. Instead of guided ascent, it becomes unguided entry. Instead of purification, erasure. Instead of pilgrimage infrastructure, anti-infrastructure. Instead of returning transformed, not returning at all.